Pablo: Driving Through a War

A volunteer evacuation bus driver in Ukraine, filmed April 2022, after a Shiftwave session

Setting the stage

On February 24, 2022, Russia launched its full-scale invasion of Ukraine. In the weeks that followed, millions of people fled their homes. Long lines of cars, buses, and people on foot headed west toward the borders with Poland and other neighboring countries, many of them women, children, and older people.

Much of that movement depended on ordinary people behind the wheel. Volunteer drivers made run after run, often for days on end, carrying families out of danger. They drove under constant pressure: crowded roads, little sleep, and the weight of the people in their seats.

Who Pablo is

Pablo is one of those volunteer drivers. In April 2022, about six weeks into the invasion, the man filming him describes him as driving buses "day and night all over Ukraine, going right into the front lines and evacuating women and children and orphans." He was filmed right after a session on a Shiftwave system. He speaks in Russian and Ukrainian, translated into English below.

In their words

> "They're just not getting any sleep, they're totally stressed out, and they're being exposed to trauma themselves."
>
> The person filming, describing the drivers

> "Stress, yes. It's gone. The stress is leaving."
>
> Pablo, asked how he feels after the session

> "My head is freeing up. It was clenched, it was tight."
>
> Pablo

> "It will be a great help for our guys, who are saving people, who are saving children."
>
> Pablo, on what this means for the other drivers

> "They need some serious on-demand R&R."
>
> The person filming

Why this matters to truckers

- **The same road, different stakes.** Long hours, tight schedules, irregular sleep, and miles of focus are part of every professional driver's life. Pablo's runs pushed all of those to the extreme.

- **Stress builds up behind the wheel.** Pablo describes his head as "clenched" and "tight" before the session. Many drivers will recognize that feeling at the end of a long haul.
- **Recovery has to fit the job.** With evacuations running day and night, there was little time off. A reset had to happen between runs, right where the drivers were.
- **Drivers look out for each other.** Pablo's first thought after his session was for the other drivers: "This will be a big help for our guys."

Watch the 72-second video with English subtitles:
gordonshiftwave.github.io/shiftwave-ukrainian-memos-en/#video

Pablo's words were translated from Russian and Ukrainian. These are one driver's personal experiences, not medical claims.